countries. Prior to 1907, tentative attempts had been made to improve the state of affairs between Britain and Russia, but to no avail.[15] By the time of the agreement, however, many factors had come together to create a suitable ground for compromise, not least of which was a growing fear in both Britain and Russia regarding German ambition in the Middle East and Asia. For Britain, Germany had come to be regarded as a potential naval competitor,[16] while the proposed Baghdad Railway – with its starting point in Berlin – was a potential threat to Britain's position in the Persian Gulf.[17] There was also a considerable fear in Britain by the early twentieth century that, should Russia end up allying itself with Germany, France might well be forced to follow suit and Britain could find itself diplomatically and militarily isolated in Europe. It was well known that Kaiser Wilhelm and Tsar Nicholas II corresponded regularly (they were, after all, uncle and nephew).[18] In order not to become isolated and to preserve a balance of power in Europe (that Edwardian obsession), Britain therefore needed to improve relations with Russia. Since it was the scene of the Great Game, Asia, which had always brought Anglo-Russian relations to the boil, in 1907 it was in Asia that a rapport was now sought.

For Russia too, the time was apt for seeking a resolution to the military and diplomatic tension of the nineteenth century. By 1905 not only had it suffered a humiliating defeat at the hands of the Japanese, it had been internally rocked by revolution and mass popular discontent. Domestically in turmoil, Russia needed to find stability in its foreign affairs in order to concentrate on its internal problems. Militarily weakened, there was also a fear that the other major powers would be able to take advantage of Russia.[19] Much like Britain, Russia also hoped that the convention would help to protect it from growing German aggression. Suspicion had begun to develop among many in Russia that, while Germany professed friendship toward them, Berlin was actually more interested in domination than mutual alliance.[20] Wilhelm had greatly encouraged Nicholas II in declaring war on Japan in 1904, and Izvolskii believed that by turning Russia's attention eastward, Germany was trying to secure its own ascendancy over Europe.[21] Hence, it was a common European enemy that ultimately helped to cool down Anglo-Russian rivalry in Asia. And, to some extent, the convention certainly encouraged better relations between the two signatories. Germany's belligerency only increased after 1907, and its actions during the